THIS PHOTO WON THE PULITZER PRIZE IN 1974 BUT HAS A BITTER OUTCOME

THINGS ARE NOT ALWAYS AS THEY SEEM

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In 1973, a single photograph, ***"Burst of Joy,"*** captured a jubilant family rushing toward a returning POW, encapsulating a rare moment of pure emotion amidst the lingering shadows of the Vietnam War.

Taken at Travis Air Force Base in California, the image symbolized hope and reunion, and its power earned it the *Pulitzer Prize the following year*. But behind the euphoria and celebration, the true story carried a haunting twist that reshaped the narrative.

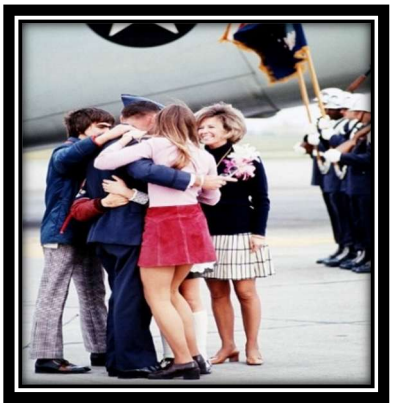
The Vietnam War left deep scars on the American psyche, and moments of joy like this were few and far between. ***On March 17, 1973,*** Lt. Col. Robert L. Stirm, an Air Force fighter pilot, returned home after six harrowing years as a prisoner of war in North Vietnam. Shot down in 1967, he endured years of torture, gunshot wounds, mock executions, and captivity. His family had long feared the worst, and his unexpected survival felt like a miracle.

Waiting for him on the tarmac were his wife, Loretta, and their four children: Lorrie, 15, leading the charge; her brother Robert Jr.; sister Cindy; and youngest brother Roger, 12. The photograph captured the raw, unfiltered joy as they sprinted toward him. Lorrie, dressed in a carefully chosen fuchsia miniskirt, her arms outstretched, became the heart of the image, earning her the nickname "The Leaper." Photographer Slava "Sal" Veder instinctively captured the moment, preserving an indelible piece of history.

The photo spread like wildfire, gracing the front pages of newspapers across the nation. For many, it became the ultimate symbol of homecoming and national healing, representing every family waiting for loved ones to return. Yet the image didn't tell the full story, concealing a heartbreak that cast a long shadow over the reunion.

Just three days before stepping onto American soil, Lt. Col. Stirm received devastating news. A military chaplain delivered a letter from Loretta, a "Dear John" message that shattered his hopes of returning to a stable family life. In the letter, Loretta informed him that their marriage was over. "I have changed drastically," she wrote. "Bob, I feel sure that in your heart you know we can't make it together… Life is too short."

During Stirm's years in captivity, Loretta had faced immense challenges raising their four children alone. *She had also entered relationships with other men, three of whom proposed to her.* By the time Stirm returned, Loretta had already moved on emotionally, leaving him to grapple with the dual burden of war's trauma and personal betrayal.



The image that had come to symbolize triumph and unity was, for Stirm, a bittersweet reminder of loss. Reflecting on its years later, he admitted, “I can’t help but feel ambivalent about it. I was very pleased to see my children—I loved them and still do—but there was a lot to deal with.”

Within a year of his return, Robert and Loretta divorced. Loretta quickly remarried and relocated to Texas with her new husband. Despite her infidelity, a judge ordered Stirm to give Loretta 43% of his military retirement pay, a decision he viewed as ironic and unjust. “She lived a lie,” he later remarked, expressing frustration at how the legal system failed to reflect the reality of their marriage’s breakdown.

His wife took $140,000 of his pay while he was a POW, took his two younger kids, house, car, 40% of his future pension, and $300 a month in child support. She had to pay back only $1500 of his money used on trips with other men.

He fought and lost against her in court. He then had to live with his mom in San Francisco taking care of his older kids. It looks more like Prisoner of Wife.

The divorce split the family, with Lorrie and Robert Jr. staying with their father while Cindy and Roger lived with their mother. The emotional toll on the children was profound. “There was so much that my dad missed out on,” Lorrie said. “It took a while to let him back into our lives and accept his authority.”

For years, Stirm refused to display Burst of Joy in his home, unable to reconcile the public image with his private pain. Yet his children found meaning in the photograph, each hanging a copy in their homes. “It’s a wonderful piece of history,” Lorrie said. “It brings back all the joy that was there.” Her younger sister Cindy, however, felt a sense of distance. “It seems like another lifetime ago,” she reflected. “I look at the picture, and I don’t see me. I didn’t really know him when he left.”

Loretta’s presence in the photo puzzled many, given her decision to end the marriage. But her daughter Lorrie acknowledged the challenges she faced. “She had a rough job, raising four children on her own,” she explained. Loretta had been just 19 when she married Robert after his graduation from Air Force cadet school. Their relationship began with hope but ultimately crumbled under the weight of war and time.

Robert Stirm went on to remarry, though his second marriage also ended in divorce. *Loretta passed away from cancer in 2010, 36 years after their divorce.* Despite the family’s fractured history, the *Burst of Joy* photograph remains a powerful symbol of resilience and reunion, even as it reminds us of the hidden complexities behind every image.

The photograph endures as a representation of a generation scarred by war, yet striving for healing.

For Lt. Col. Robert L. Stirm, the joy it captured was inextricably linked with heartbreak—a poignant reminder that even the most iconic moments are layered with unseen struggles.

As we reflect on this iconic image, we are reminded of the sacrifices made not only by those who serve but also by the families who wait and the stories that lie beneath the surface of history.

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TO THE WORLD, the photo of his family greeting the Air Force officer after his return from a North Vietnamese camp symbolized the joy of a nation leaving an ugly war. To him, the scene was and remains a lie.

His older daughter is racing to meet him, arms outstretched, both feet off the ground, face split wide in a giddy smile. Close behind on the tarmac, also running, are his two grinning boys; his younger daughter; his tall, attractive wife.

The joy of this reunion leaps out from the pages of history: Robert Stirm, crisp in his Air Force uniform, was finally home after *nearly 5 1/2 years in the prison camps of Vietnam.*

The Pulitzer Prize-winning picture that captured that very personal, yet most public of moments symbolizes the end of U.S. involvement in the Vietnam War, the bittersweet homecoming of 591 POWs in 1973. ***Twenty years later, the picture is very different***.

In his home near San Francisco, a Vietnam history book is opened to that page of Stirm's life. He gazes at it. "I have several copies of the photo," he says, "but I don't display it in the house."

Why? Stirm laughs. He points to the picture, to the tall woman – just outpacing her younger son – dressed in a blue-and-white pleated skirt and blue sweater, sporting a large corsage. "Because of her," he says simply.

Stirm's anger and bitterness these two decades later seem directed more at the woman in the famous black-and-white photo – his former wife, Loretta – than at the Vietnamese captors who tortured him.

He says he survived the torture, the mock executions, the dread-filled days and nights, so he could return to her, only to be handed a "Dear John" letter by a chaplain upon his release.

"I have changed drastically – forced into a situation where I finally had to grow up," the letter read in part. "Bob, I feel sure that in your heart you know we can't make it together – and it doesn't make sense to be unhappy when you can do something about it. Life is too short."

To Stirm, 60, it is cruel irony that so public a reunion had so hollow a core. The photo, taken by Sal Veder of The Associated Press, "brought a lot of notoriety and publicity to me and, unfortunately, the legal situation that I was going to be faced with, and it was kind of unwelcome," Stirm said.

"In some ways, it's hypocritical, because my former wife had abandoned the marriage within a year or so after I was shot down. And she did not even have the honor and integrity to be honest with the kids. She lived a lie. This picture does not show the realities that she had accepted proposals of marriage from three different men. . . . It portrays everybody there as happy to see me."

But for Stirm's older daughter, Lorrie Kitching, the photo captures a wonderful, pure moment in time. It brought basket after basket of fan mail and newspaper clippings from all over the world, she recalls.

Lorrie, 35, lives in San Mateo, Calif., with her second husband and an 11-year-old son from her first marriage. She works in the sales department of Media Sourcery, marketers of multimedia software.

Tears filled her eyes as she looked at the picture recently and saw her 15 1/2-year-old self about to leap into her father's arms, her airborne feet in her first high heels.

“It’s a wonderful piece of history that we just happened to stumble into,” she says. “It never would have gone away in my mind, but seeing that photo brings it all back again – just all the joy that was there.

“It was like Christmas. You knew Christmas was going to be great, but you didn’t really know what was going to happen on Christmas, and that was just like when Dad came home.

It was Christmas morning. You were racing down the stairs because we knew that there was a great present waiting for us. Everybody’s face is genuinely happy.”

Directly behind Lorrie in the photo is Cindy, the youngest child. She had turned 11 two days before her father returned home. She is wearing her favorite dress, a black jumper with a lacy pinafore, knee socks and Mary Janes.

Today, she is Cindy Pierson, 31, the mother of an 8-year-old girl. “It seems like another lifetime ago,” she says. “I look at the picture, and I don’t see me. . . . I don’t feel like I was really a part of it. I was so young. I didn’t really know him when he left and I thought it would be wonderful to have a dad because all my friends had dads at their functions.”

Robert Stirm Jr. is 34 now, the father of three sons and a dentist in Concord, Calif. *His sister, Cindy*, is his office manager. In the photo, he is 14, with a broad smile on his face.

“People recognized this photo,” he says. “There’s some sort of notoriety in that. But the photo per se didn’t really change my life – it was my father coming home that changed my life.”

Roger, 12 at the time, trails everyone. He followed in his father’s footsteps; he is a captain in the Air Force. *And Loretta? She is married to a lawyer and still lives in Foster City.* ***She declined to be interviewed*** *-(she died in 2010)*

No one is sure why she showed up at Travis Air Force Base in California that St. Patrick’s Day in 1973, but she alluded to it in the letter handed to Stirm when he arrived in the Philippines before returning to the United States.

“I love you – we all love you, but you must remember how very unhappy we were together,” it said. “It wasn’t your fault – we are extremely unsuited and managed to make each other miserable. . . .

“I can’t begin to tell you how proud we are of you. The children and I never missed a night saying a prayer for your safe return. I have your pictures up and your certificates and have kept you very much with us while you were gone and the children have not forgotten their father.

“I would like to see you when you come home, but will understand if you would rather not.” Bob and Loretta met at a party just after he graduated from Air Force cadet school; they were married in 1955 when she was 19. They divorced a year after he returned from Vietnam, *and each remarried within six months.*

“She had a rough job, raising four children on her own,” Lorrie says. “She was very young.” Stirm was awarded custody of Lorrie and Robert Jr.; Loretta was given custody of Roger and Cindy. She also received the home and 42.9 percent of Stirm’s retirement pay, though the judge said a great deal of evidence showed a pattern of misconduct on her part during Stirm’s imprisonment.

“It’s not fair. It’s not just,” Stirm says now. “I’m the one that lives with all the aches and pains from my imprisonment, but she continues to get paid.” Still, he says, the couple have come together for weddings and other family events, *and all four children are on good terms with both parents.*

Stirm retired from the Air Force in 1977 after 25 years of service. He joined Ferry Steel Products, the business his grandfather started in San Francisco, but found it ungratifying. He returned a few years ago,

however, after the company that hired him as a corporate pilot went bankrupt. Though it revives the pain, it is inevitable that he see the picture again from time to time.

“The momentum to stay alive for my family’s sake was very strong, because I had four neat children,” he says quietly, “and what I believed to be a neat wife that I wanted to get back to see.



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